

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 11
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Healing Division
16 August 2026

LVF updated 6pm Monday

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML & Lauren Seely

STRIPS OF PAPER IN PROGRAM FOR PRAYERS

Tech: we will need the piano for the offertory anthem, and one microphone for offertory solo. SOUND CHECK AT 8:45 AM

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[ML & ... center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Words of Gathering

ML & ...

We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.

The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.

The needs of those to come call upon us this day.

What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?

What will we leave behind?

*May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope
be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully-
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet to come
in these perilous and precious days
we have been given.*

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

[-enfleshed]

***Hymn of Gathering**

 **From Wisdom Emerging (ST. DENIO).pdf**

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
for people converging in safety and grace,
to shelter the freedom of one and of all
in Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
with others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
we walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
we joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,
we follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness and Confession**

ML

Holy One of freedom and liberation and reconciliation -
you have given us the law, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.

Still we struggle.

The complexities of life and challenges of being human
often win over. In our pain we harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.

Forgive us, O God.

And then, Gracious One,
ground our lives in mutual care and connection,
as we share with you - a vision of the belovedness
of each one of us, which is always and forever -
the cornerstone of your collective reality.

***For this and so much more, we are grateful.
Amen and Amen!***

[adpt/enfleshed]

***Introit**

Let All the World in Every Corner Sing

Ralph Vaughan Williams

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*; Dr. Emma Whitten, *Organ*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Let us join together in this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Mother of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion,
and connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourishedd
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys
and liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[-enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

In the center of the whirlwind
 lies an eye.
 Still.
 Open.
 Calm.
 Before we come into the world,
 it is as though we live in that center –
 no worries,
 no storms,
 only peace.

As we find our way in life,
 even in the midst of chaos,
 may we remember that center
 and, as the need arises,
 and it must,
 may we hold
 to the calm, open, stillness,
 knowing it as home. [gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

Please be seated

[... to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke*
Hear now this reading from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 9...

As the time approached when he was to be taken from this world, Jesus firmly resolved to proceed toward Jerusalem and sent messengers on ahead. They entered a Samaritan town to make preparations for him, but the Samaritans wouldn't welcome Jesus because his destination was Jerusalem. When the disciples James and John saw this, they said, "Rabbi, do you want us to call down fire from heaven and destroy them?" But Jesus turned and reprimanded them. Then they set off for another town.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Emma short transition Michael to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

[After 2 minutes, Emma transition out of silence and play as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

Prayer of Our Hearts

[Emma transition Laude to positions]

Meditation Anthem *That Which Can't be Explained* Peter Eldridge/Arr. Katelyn Dietz
Laude

[Emma transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon *Healing Division* **LVF**

[Emma transition ... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem *Rondo* John Carter
Brandon Harris, *Soloist*, Dr. Emma Whitten, *Piano*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[... to lectern]

***Offering Prayer**

Holy Mystery,
we pray this morning ---

*mindful of all that has brought us together,
of the Spirit of Life at work in our lives,
and of what may be possible
if we allow this Spirit to work
freely in each of us.*

*Let our generosity increase
as our lives are transformed
so that we may be
light and life in this place.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

ML: Our gardens have acquired two cats to care for the space, lovingly trained by Michael Wickstrom. Last week, our youth named the cats and Ianthe informs us that these brilliant puns come directly from the teens themselves! Please welcome to our community the cats of Amanda Scott Gardens: Bartholomew Simpson the Third, and Meowy Magdalene, middle name Jalene: representing the first initial of each of the youth's first names.

Words of Blessing

LVF

*As we leave this sacred time and space,
Let us gather our courage in community, because...
We can do hard things
Brave things
Beautiful things
Risky and transformative things.*

The Sacred travels with those who journey toward freedom.
*For the sake of the collective life
For the sake of disrupting evil
For the sake of the human soul.*

We are called and companied,
never really alone.

*May our hearts be encouraged both this day -
and in all the days to come.*

[-enfleshed]

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

Amen

Kelly McCandless

So let it be. So it shall be. Let us love one another. Amen.

***Hymn for the Journey**

 **Come Now, O Wisdom (SLANE).pdf**

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for people converging in safety and grace,
to shelter the freedom of one and of all
in Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
with others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
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[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Inside the Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini

In our musical exploration today of *healing division*, we focus on that which unites us. We begin with the call for unity —*let all the world in every corner sing*— composed by the prominent 20th century British progressive social activist Ralph Vaughan Williams, whose work was informed by his ideals that the healing properties of music should be accessible for all and not reserved for the economic elite. We hear the urgency in his invitation through the insistence of the organ line and the rhythmic pulse of the choral homophony. Sometimes *love* sounds rousing! We meditate on the theme of healing with the tune and poem *That Which Can't be explained* by Peter Eldridge, arranged by Laude's own Katelyn Dietz. In it, the singer inquires about *differences unreconciled*, questions of *shaky refuge*, and the agnostic presence of spirit,

connecting always to *loving that which can't be explained*. Sometimes *love* sounds intangible and uncertain!

Brandon and Dr. Whitten then offer us the Rondo from John Carter's Cantata which implores us to *ring-a-them-bells*, referring to the joyful anticipation of the Jesus who came to heal the nations. Sometimes *love* sounds insistent! And finally, we sing *Amen*—*let it be so*— in the Kelly McCandless sonic poem which explores the meaning of the word. In it, she discovers that *Amen*, to her, means *so let it be—so it shall be—we shall be who we are, one in the spirit. Let us love one another—Amen*. Sometimes, love sounds like radical acceptance and the healing of division.